

WBREDA Established 1993

The West Bengal Renewable Energy Development Agency ensures that the state giants use 5 per cent of renewable energy. From a solar housing programme to the country's first rice husk fuel power plant, it is a pioneer in the promotion of renewable energy.



Susobhan Bhattacharya 49, Director

BACK TO NATURE

"The new generation should know the importance of renewable energy. It is the only way to secure the future."

The director of the West Bengal Renewable Energy Development Agency (WBREDA), Susobhan Bhattacharya, has a mandate to promote: "We must understand that fossil fuel will not last forever. We have to develop alternative modes of energy, renewable energy technologies and create an environment conducive to their commercialisation through innovative projects." The WBREDA, formed in 1993 with its head office in Kolkata, has already done outstanding work in the Sunderbans with Gosaba as its focal point. The WBREDA has launched the country's first rice husk fuel power plant catering to 1,200 consumers along with the country's first high output solar power plant

which serves 1.65 lakh solar homes, the highest in the country.

The WBREDA has only 16 staff members who ensure that giants like the WBSEB, CESC and DPL in the state use 5 per cent of renewable energy with an increase of 1 per cent every year for the next 10 years starting from 2010. The Centrally-funded—approximately Rs 80 crore with a matching grant by the state Government—yet autonomous WBREDA is perhaps the only agency which does not complain about the government and says its support has been more than what was expected. The agency has already covered a fully functional solar housing project in Rajarhat near Kolkata and is set to bring power to 10,000 homes with

15,236 MW
or nearly 10 per cent is the share of renewable energy in India's total installed power generation capacity.

solar home lighting systems, provide electricity to 100 villages through renewable energy and generate 5 MW power from energy routes like solar, wind, biomass and small hydel. It is also carrying out a survey for installation of 12 MW small hydel stations in Darjeeling and providing jobs to 1,000 youths. "The new generation should be aware of the importance of renewable energy. It's the only way to secure the future," says the mechanical engineer.

According to Bhattacharya, in the next five years, the WBREDA will revolutionise the transport sector with the use of bio-diesel which is both cheaper and eco-friendly. As facilitators, for now, the goal is to extend the work to the areas of urban Kolkata and later to the whole nation, guarding the future for sure.

by Abhijit Dasgupta